

Nunnehi

Nunnehi is a Cherokee word for “people who live anywhere” and has, over time, come to be what the native faerie folk of the Americas call themselves. Before the Shattering, the Americas were filled with dozens or perhaps hundreds of different varieties of faeries, but since the sudden separation from the Dreaming, or as the Nunnehi refer to it, the Higher Hunting Grounds, many of the fae of the Americas were lost forever.

The Nunnehi are faerie just as the European changelings and share much in common with them, but they also have many differences. They do not gather Glamour, but instead, “harvest Medicine.” They do not call themselves Kithain, but rather the Nunnehi Nation, and they do not refer to kith, but instead they have Families, and they refer to their freeholds as lodges.

How the Nunnehi learned the Changeling Way is unknown, but the Nunnehi made contact with the European fae when Vikings first settled the Americas as early as the 10th century, and many believe its secrets were learned from a Nordic and Germanic fae who traveled along with those early settlers. Others claim that the Nunnehi learned to become changelings on their own and that the native fae found highly-spiritual mortals to bond with. Whatever the means, the Nunnehi survived the Shattering, but with the loss of the Higher Hunting Grounds, they were forced to learn new ways to gather Medicine. Much the same way as the Menchune (described later), they learned ways to draw Medicine directly from the natural world.

Some Nunnehi still seek a means of connecting to the Higher Hunting Grounds, but none have been successful. Speculation persists among the Nunnehi and the Kithain that their homeland in the Dreaming may have been destroyed due to the loss of so many tribes and the erosion of mortal belief.

The Nunnehi are closely bonded with the mortal tribes. Nunnehi are always born to those with native blood and most often to those who still live amongst the tribes. They continue to live at the edges of Native American society, even though most natives have forgotten them.

History

The history of the Nunnehi is a long story of bloodshed and sadness. Since the arrival of the first Europeans, long before Columbus, the Nunnehi have coped with a series of dislocations and invasions. Long before the coming of the Kithain, the Nunnehi Nations lived in harmony with the Native American tribes. Though widely varied due to differences in beliefs, the Nunnehi Families had much in common with one another. Many were invisible or could become so; some could change size from a few inches tall to gigantic. Almost all were believed to grant favors or bestow curses. Closely tied to both the natural world and the world of spirits, some served tribal shamans as conduits to higher beings or the spirits of the dead. Tribes left gifts to placate their spirit brethren, asked them for guidance, and feared their retribution should they be insulted or angered. In return, the Nunnehi Nations watched over their “flesh-brothers,” lending their assistance when needed and teaching tribal natives healing and growing magic.

The first European fae to arrive were the trolls and nockers, and even a few sidhe who accompanied the Vikings who settled on the shores of North America. Many of them, especially the sidhe, were fleeing the rising tide of Banality that was sweeping across Europe in the late 12th and 13th centuries. Relations with these fae were mostly amicable, and treaties and agreements were struck with these early arrivals.

Soon however, greater numbers came across the sea, and these settled wherever they pleased with little regard for the native faeries. Like their human counterparts who would later arrive in the New World, the European faeries arrogantly assumed that their culture and traditions were superior and more civilized. Some even took Nunnehi as captives and thralls to “teach” them European values and how to be “civilized.” Relations between the Kithain and the Nunnehi Nations quickly deteriorated and the Nunnehi began to fight back against the usurpers who took their lands — accosting travelers and razing Kithain freeholds.

European Settlement

The arrival of European settlers brought new waves of Kithain. The fate of the Nunnehi Nations